

KF52 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

This is our KF prayer using my Bible translation: “Examine me, O God, and discover my heart. Run experiments on me and become intimate with my fearful thoughts. See if there is any hurtful or idolatrous way in me, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

In this last meeting of the training cycle, we would all like to get an idea of what God is doing in the world through you. Traditionally, during the final presenting time, we each briefly share what we do for a living and how we support the wider community. Feel free to pass, if you wish.

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

Everyone who wishes to continue to have access to the KF website must re-register. Completing your registration now will keep you connected to the website and remove a burden from the hard-working KF admin team. If KF admin does not receive your registration, the system will disconnect you and move you to the “inactive” list.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Sit or stand with the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Begin with **Alternate Nostril Breathing** for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now, allow your shoulders and arms to drop into a relaxed position. As you breathe, observe your body. Are there any areas of tension that you might allow to rest? *(Pause)* Breathe, and let your body soften on the exhale. Relax your face. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Waiting on the Lord

With your eyes closed, imagine that you are looking through your forehead and into the light. Imagine that the light is pouring into your eyes. As you inhale, you might explore pulling energy up from the earth through your tailbone, filling your spinal column. As you exhale, allow the energy to drain back into the earth. Practice for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

At some point, perhaps right now, you might imagine that you are gazing into the face of Jesus, or into the glory of God. Just silently absorb and breathe for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Continue to breathe as you listen to these verses from Psalm 36 in my translation:

⁸They drink their fill from the overflow of Your house,
 And You give them to drink from the river of Your delights.
⁹For with You is the fountain of life; in Your light we see light.
¹⁰O continue Your kindness to those who know You,
 And Your faithfulness to the oriented heart.¹

Pause, and gently open your eyes. Take a deep breath and re-engage with the meeting. *(Pause)*

Our hymn for this last confession is *Be Thou My Vision*.

High King of Heaven, my victory won;
 May I reach Heaven's joys, O bright Heaven's Sun!
 Heart of my own heart, whatever befall,
 Still be my Vision, O Ruler of all.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let's listen once again to our final KF Confession:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

In these last few lessons, we have introduced the idea of flow. As we circulate our true resources, we keep the flow moving.

We learned in KF30 that there are two levels of karis. At the first level, we lay the foundation of trust, which is necessary for any karis relationship. This level has three steps. These steps are your response to God's invitation into wholeness and salvation. If you do not practice these steps, God's gifts cannot flow. By practicing these steps, you show God that you are serious about developing your relationship with Him and that you intend to learn to be trustworthy. At this first level, you train to:

- 1. Obey kingdom law:** learn God's kingdom law of orientation and obey it.
- 2. Cultivate more orientation:** learn what orientation feels like and looks like, and mindfully act in ways that cultivate it.
- 3. Choose life:** avoid misoriented behavior.

When you practice these oriented steps, you give a gift to God and to others, and you give your True Self a drink from the overflow of God's house.³ The outcome, or effect, of pursuing orientation is predictable—over time, you will create a life that is more stable, more productive, and more secure.

At this first level, you take control of your life, and in partnership with God, you create good soil that can nurture the seeds that you and He plant. You move away from reactive survival and consequence

management into a place of growth and potential. This level of karis is the prerequisite for a glorious life full of surprising opportunities. By choosing the path of orientation, you restore your crippled and stunted True Self, which the Idol has cruelly suppressed for so long; you repair the damage that you have done to yourself and the damage that others have done to you. You cannot progress to the second level of karis until you have lived at the first level for some time. Training and support to live at this first level is the greatest gift that Karis Fellowships offers you.

The second level of karis is where the adventure really begins. This level often feels strange and foreign because we have never lived there before. In one sense, this is where you let go of controlling your life; in another sense, this is where you begin to really live. You plant without the expectation of a particular result, and you reap astonishing surprises and delights. At the second level, you learn to:

1. **Love your neighbor as yourself:** treat very well those who support you.⁴
2. **Do good to the trustworthy community:** support members of the community who are investing in their true glory.
3. **Act with kindness toward the world:** offer gifts of care and support to those outside the trustworthy community.⁵

When we are healthier and more oriented, we are no longer driven by the fear of losing our Idol's life and can observe events without judgment. We mindfully acknowledge the Idol's efforts to control us, but we refuse to participate in the damage it causes. We remember what we really want: we want to enjoy more love and more life, and we want to be more capable of handling whatever life brings. When our choices are oriented toward achieving those desires, we become more trustworthy. We also learn more about God, which increases our trust and gives us the courage to continue to explore, to expand, and to extend ourselves. We reveal our growing trust in God by courageously circulating our MATH—our money, abilities, time, and health. The agape love that is gaining ground in our souls motivates us to experiment with circulating. We then watch with anticipation to see what God will do.

The outcome or effect of your circulation at this second level of karis is unpredictable. You cannot foresee what glorious things God will return to you, and you often cannot recognize any direct cause and effect between what you give and what you receive. That's because the unseen world responds to your choices according to its own laws. It will manifest itself to you in ways that you could never predict or engineer on your own. You just start drinking from the river of His delights, and in His light you see more and more light.⁶ You can never swallow too much of that river, and there is no end to what His light can reveal.

Circulation begins with letting go. We let go of trying to save the life of our Idol.⁷ We let go of our poverty mindset, which keeps us submerged in the material world where there is never enough; we let go of constantly meeting the compulsive needs of our pride system; we let go of trusting our Idol's dictates; and we let go of our egocentric life. We begin to allow our resources to flow toward a real need or a real joy. We become someone's neighbor. Rather than waiting for others to give to us, we initiate the ecosystem of circulation. We develop the empathy required to know what another person needs or what would bring them joy. Offering joy is just as valuable as meeting a need. Before we have time to talk ourselves out of it, we let our resources flow to that person. We do something; when we see our chance, we act. Our life then becomes evidence of our trust in God and His trust in us.

As we learn to trust God, we develop a magnanimous heart that responds to its own opportunities to circulate. Being magnanimous—or having a “great soul”—doesn’t mean that we let go of all of our MATH all of the time. Remember that flow is a cycle. It comes and it goes. When the flow comes in, we gather the resources we need to manage our responsibilities and our giving. When the flow goes out, we harbor our resources and learn to wait productively until the flow returns. When we budget our MATH, we make decisions about what to preserve and what to invest in the adventure. Even though our MATH is budgeted and prioritized, we do not make our budget another rigid legal system, so we can choose to stretch the comfort zone of our plans and our MATH to meet a need or a joy. This demonstrates our trust in God and gives Him the opportunity to demonstrate His trustworthiness toward us. Our choice shows God that we are trustworthy and willing to learn more trust.

When we are full of claims and shoulds, expecting others and ourselves to perform in a certain way, there is no room for gratitude. Claims and shoulds focus our attention on our hurt pride and on what we don’t have. When, on the other hand, we let go of our karis gifts and trust the flow, we give God and others the opportunity to allow their gifts to flow toward us. This giving and receiving builds our lives on a foundation of gratitude. Observe what pours out to you from God’s fountain. List those gifts on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. These lists are evidence of a life of increasing gratitude. They reveal how far you’ve gone into the flow.

Recently, someone I know gave \$1,000 to a former therapist whose work had enriched her life. Resources had suddenly become available and the therapist was on her mind, so she passed some of her riches on to the therapist. She hadn’t planned to give that particular gift, but she had been developing an attitude of continual openness to God’s guidance in the area of giving and receiving His surprising gifts. She was looking for the unexpected and then found herself able to give a gift that was outside her comfort zone. When you are living in that kind of openness, your mind is set on things above and you are baptized into the flow. This circulation of God’s gifts is probably your most powerful witness. I’ve seen people turn toward oriented and joyful living because, at just the right time, someone gave them a gift. Through the offering of a gift, another soul can experience the reality of a compassionate, personal, and imminent God.

This ongoing cycle of circulation with God allows resources to flow away from us, but it also allows resources to flow toward us. When we refuse to be motivated by greed and fear, our arms are open to give and receive. The resources of the Creation are then free to flow back and forth in a natural cycle. By allowing the tide to go out, we invite the tide’s return. As we invest our MATH, we gain even more. Through entering into circulation, we experience an ever-increasing vitality that brings with it more and more joy.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, I am willing to let go and get into the flow. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

You might want to share an area of your life that has positively changed during this year of KF training.

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

We end our training cycle with KF Confession 12:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

This is the last lesson of our training. I have offered you over fifty-two Bible passages that teach us about our glory and the karis relationship that we share with each other and with God. The Bible is full of information that invites each one of us to participate in karis. Every bit of guidance from the Bible, every call to love, and every declaration of your potential as a child of God is an invitation to respond with oriented action and trust. Your response is called faith. Faith is what it takes to fulfill the greatest commandment, which is to love God with all of our being and to love our neighbor as we would love ourselves.⁸

The parable of the Good Samaritan is recorded in all three of the synoptic gospels. You can find it in Matthew 22:37–40, Mark 12:28–34, and Luke 10:25–37. Each account of this parable contributes something unique to our understanding.

Matthew points out that loving our neighbor is exactly like loving God. This idea is supported in other writings in the New Testament. Jesus might just as well have said that when you love your neighbor, you are loving God, and when you are loving God, you are doing something for your neighbor. You cannot love God without loving your neighbor, and you cannot love your neighbor unless you love yourself. The Greek word for love that Jesus uses here is *agape*. This kind of love flows out of your own character. It is not fueled by your feelings or by your image management, nor is it driven by your compulsive needs. It flows out of who you have become in your True Self. When we love others as we love ourselves, we know that we have come to love the True Self and are taking time to attend to, appreciate, and nurture that Self. When you are loving your True Self, you will naturally extend that love to your neighbor in the flow of circulation. If you are aware that you cannot love your True Self, you can jump-start that process by acting in a loving way toward your neighbor. Remember that any kind of hoarding or grasping stops the flow. Through loving your neighbor, you start to love yourself.

Mark reminds us that loving God and our neighbor is greater than any kind of legalistic sacrifice. He also emphasizes that there is only one God. Our Idol Self has to go. In Mark 12:32–34, the lawyer, or teacher of religious law, agrees with Jesus that the greatest commandment is to love God and our neighbor, and Jesus responds by telling him that he is not far from the kingdom of God. However, being *not far from* the kingdom is not the same as being *in* the kingdom. The lawyer certainly knows about the kingdom, but that doesn't mean that he is living as a citizen of the kingdom. Knowing is not doing. Only action is action. Without action we are not people of faith.

Luke tells us who the neighbor is. In all of my church and theological experience I have only once heard this passage explained correctly. It was so feebly done, however, that I don't think the congregation really understood the point the preacher was trying to make. In Luke's account, a lawyer asks Jesus which commandment is the greatest. Jesus responds with an answer that stirs up the lawyer's self-hate because Jesus emphasizes action not simply knowledge. The lawyer is proud of his scriptural knowledge, but Jesus challenges him to translate what he knows into action. The lawyer then finds himself entangled in the conflict between knowing what to do and yet being unwilling to do it. He feels anxious and tries to justify his inaction by asserting that the commandment is too vague for anyone to follow. He takes refuge in semantics by asking Jesus, "Who is my neighbor?"

I want to point out something in this passage that might surprise you. We are often taught that the neighbor is the one who was left for dead, the needy one. That is not what Jesus says. Jesus tells us that the neighbor is the one who has compassion and helps the one who has fallen into the hands of robbers. Neighbors take action on our behalf. The ones who take action on our behalf are the ones we are commanded to love as ourselves. I believe that no one is truly alive until they start to contribute. Karis Fellowships training requires effort, and through this effort we learn to contribute and pump the circulation of Creation, inviting others and God into a great circulating love relationship. Only those who make the effort to respond to God will access this love—a love that builds self-confidence and self-esteem and, also, expands our capacity for joy.

Let's look at **Luke 10:25–37** in my translation. To help our understanding, I have used the phrase *the one near* instead of the word *neighbor*.

²⁵And look, a certain expert in law stood up testing Jesus. He said, “Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?” ²⁶Jesus said to him, “What is written in the law? How do you read it?” ²⁷The lawyer replied, “You shall love the Lord your God out of the source of your desires, and from within your whole conscious self, your whole strength, and all of your intelligence; and you shall love the one near you as you would love yourself.” ²⁸Jesus said to him, “You have answered correctly. Do this, and you will live.” ²⁹But the expert in law, wishing to support his pride, said to Jesus, “And who is the one near me?”

³⁰Jesus replied, “A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho and he fell among thieves. They stripped off his clothes and beat him, wounding him, and then they disbanded, leaving him half-dead. ³¹By coincidence, a priest was going down the same road and saw the crime victim. Far from going near him, he went to the opposite side of the road to pass him by. ³²A Levite who was coming down to that place also saw the wounded man and, in just the same way, passed by on the other side in order to get as far away from him as possible.

³³A Samaritan who was on a journey came upon the victim and, seeing him, felt compassion. ³⁴And he came near to him, bandaged his traumas, pouring upon them soothing oil and healing wine. He lifted the man onto his own beast and, leading him to a place to rest, took an interest in him. ³⁵On the next day he took out two denarii and gave them to the innkeeper (the one who receives everyone), and he said, ‘Take an interest in this man, and whatever more you spend, when I return, I myself will repay you.’

³⁶Now, in your opinion, which of these three people became the one near—or the neighbor—to him who was overwhelmed by thieves?” ³⁷The expert in law said, “The one who acted mercifully toward him.” Jesus said to the lawyer, “Go on your way, and you yourself do likewise.”

Take a deep breath.

Notice that the neighbor is not the religious leader or the person who claims special spiritual authority based on antecedents. Jesus teaches us that our neighbor is the one who comes near. The neighbor rescues and helps us when we have been set upon by robbers who have exploited and abused us for their own gain. We might look back on our lives and think to ourselves: “If it wasn’t for that person and their gifts to me, where would I be?” If you shudder at the thought of where you might be, then you have found

your neighbor. Your neighbors are those who extend themselves and offer their own MATH on your behalf, not because you deserve it or because you made the first gesture, but because karis neighbors know how to love. They are the instrument of God's love in your life. When your neighbor offers you a karis gift, God uses that gift to invite you into deeper karis relationship with Him. Their gift becomes God's gift; He works through them to benefit you. So, when you respond to your neighbor with a gift of your own, you are responding to God.

When out of gratitude you offer something costly to your neighbor, you are saying to God: "I am ready to be in a growing relationship of trust—a relationship that requires courage for adventure, an ever-developing orientation, a commitment to reality, and new levels of endurance. I want a relationship that will help me step up to my design and purpose, and will train me to receive my inheritance. I am ready to declare the glory that is mine in Christ Jesus." Your neighbors are those people who take action to support you in that marvelous process of becoming God's trustworthy friend. How you respond to your neighbor declares to heaven your real intentions.

Neighbors are very valuable members of the community. You need their support and they need yours. Offer gifts to those who have rescued and supported you, and then become a neighbor to others by taking the initiative to circulate with them. If you follow the example of the Samaritan, you will discover what gifts you have to share. Show mercy to someone who has been set upon by robbers in this misoriented and destructive culture. Become God's karis gift and see what happens.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, I'm ready to become a neighbor. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider who might be your neighbor. What could it look like to love your neighbor as yourself? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or

feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Observe whatever tension you may be experiencing as you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*. (Pause) Feelings and fleeting thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*. What sensations are there? (Pause) Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what hoarding or what curiosity feels like in your body. (Pause) If your sensations are too uncomfortable, you can direct your attention to an area of the body that is not reacting, and rest. Knowing that you have a choice may give you the confidence to observe the uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. (Pause) Do you judge loving your neighbor as yourself as good or, perhaps, as evil because it scares you? Like the lawyer, you may feel skeptical or defensive, or you may be full of excuses. (Pause) What do you believe about your neighbors, those who have supported and even rescued you? What story do you want to tell? (Pause) Are you afraid of something? Do you hope for something? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered loving their neighbor as they love themselves*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. (Pause) Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. (Pause) When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe, and with compassion allow your body to process this experience with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are very grateful for this year of training together. Hold us in the power of this karis understanding and continue to guide us to our glory. As we co-labor with You, reveal the truth of who You created us to be with all of our potential in Christ. Help us to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with our community and the rest of the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

This is the last meeting in the Karis Fellowship training cycle. We hope to hear your voices next week as we welcome new members into our community and begin the cycle again. All current KF members who wish to join us, please register on the website.

¹ Psalm 36:8–10.

² www.youtube.com/watch?v=ihJAJA4ibEs.

³ Psalm 36:8.

⁴ Luke 10:27.

⁵ Galatians 6:10.

⁶ Psalm 36:9.

⁷ Luke 9:24.

⁸ Mark 12:28–34.